

ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

Sense and Sensitivity



These are disconcerting times. The other day I took an auto with my elder son, yet to turn 11. He whispered that the driver was wearing a headscarf. "So?" I asked. "He's a Muslim," he said in an agonised voice. Every day, in every way, Muslims are being seen as the other. A discourse once restricted to Pravin Togadia is now every urban parent's nightmare. In a world where students as young as 10 are learning to live with weekly school visits by bomb disposal squads and children younger than that are learning that tiffin boxes can be time bombs, the "us versus them" is no longer an issue of people like them. It is a question staring people like us. In the face. At point-blank range.

The reality is that 24-hour news channels, with their constant stream of police information about a new Muslim terrorist born every hour, has become the wallpaper of our lives. Movies, hitherto the bastion of the *Mere Mehboob* kind of genteel Muslim, are worse, creating an increasingly rabid profile of Islam in impressionable young minds. *Aamir* was a well-made film. But it also showed a fundamentalist Muslim trying mind control tactics on another Muslim, educated, foreign-returned, pushed into planting a bomb in a bus. *A Wednesday* was a powerful film, but it was also a virulent one, showing the citizen as vigilante, taking on four Muslim terrorists, each one of them signing off proudly with a riot. The language on screen has coarsened. Kay Kay Menon, playing a Hindu fundamentalist layabout in *Mumbai Meri Jaan*, says disgustedly while in a Muslim neighbourhood and hearing a Mohammed Rafi song: "Yeh log Kishore Kumar kabhi nahin sunenge". This is not the innocent tokenism of *Amar Akbar Anthony* where Akbar, the Muslim, chewed paan, sang qawwalis and wore an achkan with élan. This is the Muslim who went from being the underworld bhai with foreign friends to the homegrown terrorist of today, first seen in movies such as *Fiza*, *Mission Kashmir* and *Dev*. Still, the Muslim was either converted by love or the family he left behind embraced the nation. The change crept in with the awful *Fanaa* where Aamir Khan's terrorist dies unrepentant. It has been downhill since then, film after film—the link between Islam and domestic terrorism is intensified.

Can our children, fed on these images, ever think of Islam as anything but dangerous? And to think 20 years ago, when I began my career as a journalism trainee, the first thing I was told was, never ever refer to Muslims or Hindus in a news story on riots. It was always "members of a particular community". Yes, we were playing censor. But we were also being sensible. And sensitive.



KEEPING HIS COUNSEL: Alam

MAHADEO SEN

Defection Deadline

RANCHI The Jharkhand High Court wants Assembly Speaker Alamgir Alam to spell out a deadline within which he can dispose of the pending cases of anti-defection across parties. These include cases against ministers in the state Government. The Speaker, however, has said a firm "no" to a specific timeframe "within which all proceedings can be decided".

Overall, there are 11 cases of anti-defection in the 82-member House that are pending before the Speaker for adjudication. Five of these MLAs are ministers. The list includes Kamlesh Singh, who has been minister in all the four governments constituted within three years of the present Jharkhand House. A case against Singh is pending since 2005 while the cases against Deputy Chief Minister Stephen Marandi and ministers Anosh Ekka and Bandhu Tirkey date back to 2006.

On the face of it, the delay in adjudication has allowed these MLAs in the past to decisively swing

the balance in favour of NDA and UPA alliances. For instance, the first UPA Government in Jharkhand under Shibu Soren lasted for only nine days in 2005 because he failed to muster a majority on the floor of the House. Singh, an NCP legislator and a minister in Soren's government, had stayed away from the Assembly at that time. Following Soren's resignation, when BJP's Arjun Munda formed the Government, Singh and other independents won ministerial berths. These MLAs again switched sides and joined Madhu Koda to become ministers in the UPA-backed government. Last month, they all dumped Koda and joined hands with Soren once again.

According to the Speaker's counsel Sohail Anvar, efforts are being made to finish the proceedings as expeditiously as possible. But no time-frame can be spelled out. The Jharkhand High Court has now fixed a new date for hearing. It's time to keep fingers crossed.

by Amitabh Srivastava